

1630 ▶ 1650

“It is not enough to have a good mind. The main thing is to use it well.”

René Descartes,
Discourse on the Method



Cinchona leaves and bark

1631

Wonder drug

Agostino Salumbrino, an Italian missionary living in Peru, noticed that the Quechua people used the powdered bark of the local cinchona tree to treat fever. A small sample was sent to Rome, where it was used successfully to treat malaria, then a common disease in marshy parts of Europe. We now know that cinchona bark contains a drug called quinine.



Descartes's *Discourse on the Method*

1637

Mathematical puzzle

French mathematician Pierre de Fermat scribbled a theorem (a mathematical statement) in the margin of an old textbook. He claimed he had proof that his theorem was true, but had no room to write out the answer. Fermat's theorem was not solved until 1995.



Pierre de Fermat



1630

1634

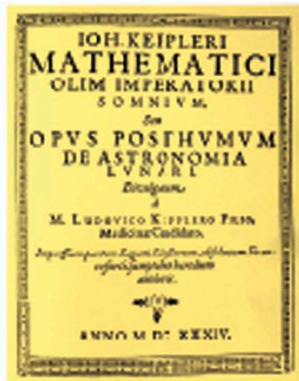
1638

1633

The trial of Galileo

Italian astronomer Galileo Galilei was put on trial in Rome on charges of heresy. He had published a book attacking the Church's view that the Earth was at the center of the Universe and supported Polish astronomer Nicolaus Copernicus's theory of a Sun-centered Universe. Fearing torture or death, Galileo denied his beliefs in court.

Galileo Galilei
See pages 68–69



Title page of *Somnium*

1634

First sci-fi novel

Johannes Kepler, a German astronomer, wrote a story about a young Icelandic boy who was taken by demons to the Moon. The novel was published a year after Kepler's death in 1633. Written in Latin, it was titled *Somnium* (The Dream), and has been described as the first work of science fiction.

1639

Transit of Venus

English astronomer Jeremiah Horrocks correctly predicted that the shadow of the planet Venus would pass in front of the Sun, a rare event known as the transit of Venus. To observe the occurrence, Horrocks projected the Sun's image through a telescope onto a sheet of paper.



Roundel from a stained glass window celebrates Horrocks's observation of the transit of Venus